

know about most of them and punished them severely. He came across as soft-spoken and down-to-earth, but could be pretty ruthless with people who tried to double-cross him.

Monk told me of an episode when Ketan learnt that one of his brokers was cheating on him. That broker's rival squealed on him to Ketan, who checked out the information to find, after a couple of deals with the suspect broker, that it was true. Two days later, Ketan gave him an order to buy a stock that had been rising the last few days. The broker bought a good-sized chunk for himself before executing the order. Minutes after he had placed the order, Ketan offloaded a big lot of that stock through his other associates. The broker suffered a huge loss and rushed to Ketan's office pleading for help. A few other brokers too were chastened in a similar fashion. But despite Ketan's efforts to keep his brokers under his thumb, there was always somebody or the other who would try to front-run him. There was no way he could control every single one of them.

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Not long ago a recluse who took pains to stay away from the spotlight, Ketan slowly began shedding his reserve. He now seemed to delight in flaunting his success and connections, and could be regularly seen socializing with Bollywood moguls and stars. Great was the surprise when Ketan threw a grand New Year party at a beachside resort in Mandwa, a short boat ride from the Gateway of India, to welcome the new millennium. The guest list included rising IT czars, Bollywood celebrities, senior corporate treasury officials, fund managers and Ketan's associates in the industry. For an industry that thrived on secrecy and discretion, Ketan's brazen show of power upset many of the old-timers.

'The guy is drawing the attention of the government and tax department on us; there will be trouble before long,' one of GB's friends said.

'Not to mention the underworld,' remarked another, '*Saala, khud toh doobegaa hi, saath mein hum sab ko bhi duba dega* (he will sink, and drag us down as well).'

And if you are wondering whether I was invited, all I can say is I was yet to show up on Ketan's radar. He would have known of me through Monk but did not think me important enough to meet with yet. That hurt my pride not a little, I must say.